

Milestone 1

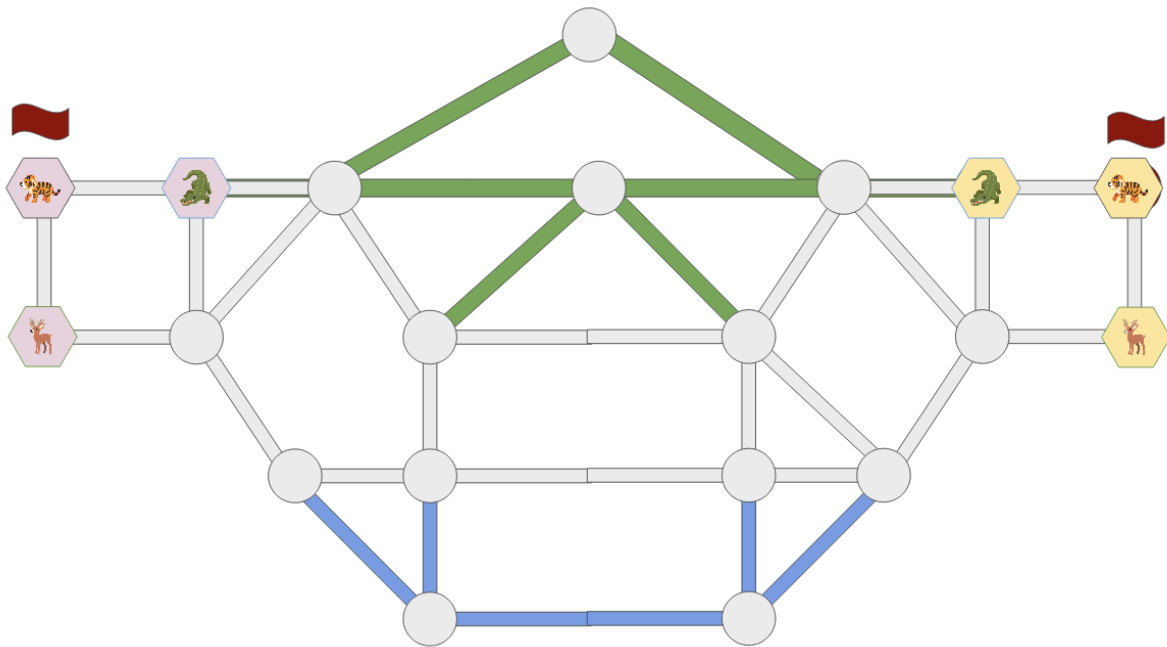
Group member: Mujia Chen, Jingyu Fu, Yingxuan Hu, Yuning Wen

Prototype 1

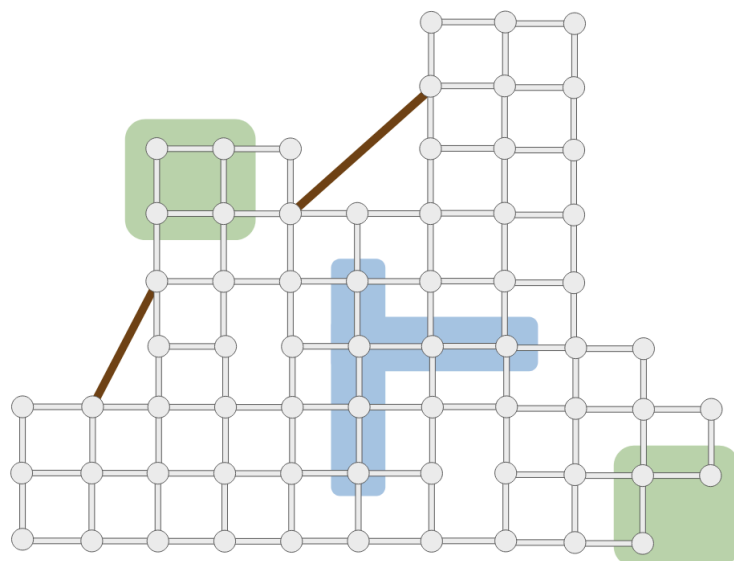
What was the idea? The mechanics and the core loop.

A 2-player abstract strategy game. Strip-down reimagining of Jungle set on a grid-style /node-and-edge board. Each player controls 3 animal pieces with a rock-paper-scissors / cascading - down cycle, moving across terrain-gated routes to either eliminate all enemy pieces or invade the enemy's home territory.

The Board: a planar checker board (grids) connected by colored grids/edges (routes). //The board is asymmetric by design — Player 2's side has one extra diagonal route to compensate for moving second.



Some other map ideas:



Pieces: Each player has the same three pieces. P1 tokens are purple, P2 tokens are yellow.

Piece	Terrain Access	Beats	Loses to
Tiger	Land	Crocodile, Deer	Deer
Deer	Land + Forest	Tiger	Crocodile, Tiger
Crocodile	Land + Water	Deer	Tiger

Starting positions: All 3 pieces begin inside their respective home wing.

Rules:

1. Players alternate turns. P1 goes first. On your turn, move exactly one piece one step along any passable adjacent edge.
2. You may not move onto a node occupied by your own piece.
3. Moving onto an enemy piece triggers combat — the losing piece is permanently removed. The winner stays. There is no retreat.
4. Win by Elimination — capture all 3 enemy pieces, or Win by Invasion — move any piece into any node of the enemy home wing.

Each player controls three animal pieces: a Tiger, a Crocodile, and a Deer. Rather than a uniform grid, the board is a planar graph of nodes connected by color-coded edges representing different terrain types. Movement is terrain-gated: Tigers may only travel along land routes (gray lines), Crocodiles along land and water routes (gray and blue), and Deer exclusively along forest routes (green lines). This means each piece inhabits a partially separate movement layer of the same board — players are effectively managing three sub-games simultaneously.

Combat is resolved by a non-circular hierarchy rather than rock-paper-scissors: Tiger beats both Crocodile and Deer; Deer beats Tiger; Crocodile beats Deer only. Pieces of the same type may capture each other. This creates a genuine dominant piece (Tiger) whose value is constrained not by a counter in the cycle but by its limited terrain access — it can never reach forest or water routes, making it a powerful but positionally rigid unit.

The core loop on each turn is: select one piece, move it one step along a passable edge, resolve combat if an enemy occupies the destination. Win by capturing all three enemy pieces, or by moving any piece into the opponent's home wing nodes.

The board is intentionally asymmetric: Player 2's side features one additional diagonal land route with no equivalent on Player 1's side, designed to offset the first-mover advantage.

How did you prototype this idea?

The prototype was developed digitally as a Figma/Axure (HTML) application, requiring no build tools or external dependencies. The visual language directly reflects the design intent: land edges are rendered as solid gray lines, water edges as blue dashed lines, and forest edges as solid green lines. Piece tokens are hexagonal, color-coded by player (pink for Player 1, yellow for Player 2), with emoji icons for the animal type. Selected pieces highlight with a glow, and valid move destinations are indicated by a green dashed ring around the target node — no rulebook required during play. The board layout was iterated upon across multiple versions to better match the intended reference map, with the home wing clusters separated visually from the main body and the asymmetric extra route placed on Player 2's side.

How many times did you playtest this idea?

I've tested it twice and both tests run for about 10 minutes.

What were your feedback and observations?

The map might need some revision. The current map is a little too big, so players often waste time waiting for the tiger to come out since the other two pieces can easily remain in their respective areas and remain locked in a stalemate.

Overall, how successful was your prototype? Was it engaging? Did it adhere to your original vision? Is it worth pursuing and iterating on further?

This prototype is kinda successful because the rules are easy to follow, and the time is controlled well, but might need to add a more engaging component. It follows the concept of food chain in the original vision well. I think it's worth pursuing and iterating on further.

Prototype 2

What was the idea? The mechanics and the core loop.

A two-player abstract strategy board game inspired by Jungle Chess. The goal shifts from “reaching the den” to “competing for limited resources”.

Uses minimal mechanics to represent a survival loop:

Resource gain → temporary power increase

Resource loss → weakness / pressure

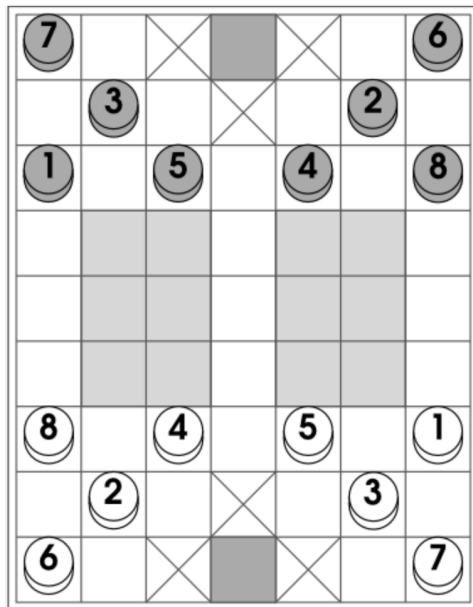
Focus on risk-based decision making: aggression, positioning, and timing

Board: 7×9 grid (similar to Jungle Chess)

Each player has 8 animal pieces with ranks (1–8)

Capture rule: higher rank defeats lower rank

Win Condition: First player to collect 3 resources wins



5 resource tiles randomly placed on the board. A piece must stay on a resource tile for one full turn to claim it.

Reward (choose one simple version):

- Temporary +1 rank for that piece (one turn)
- OR one-time ability to defeat an higher-rank piece

Hunger Mechanic: If a player fails to gain any resource for 2 consecutive turns: One of their pieces becomes “Hungry”

- Hungry effect:
 - Cannot capture equal-rank enemies
 - Movement becomes restricted

Corpse Mechanic: When a piece is captured, it leaves a “corpse” for 1 turn

- Adjacent piece can consume it (spend one turn) to gain a buff
- Corpse disappears after one round

Terrain

- Swamp: entering piece cannot move next turn but can capture corpses in Swamp to be strengthened
- High Ground: +1 rank when defending, but cannot collect resources

Turn: Players alternate turns

- Each turn: Move one piece (1 tile)
- Resolve capture if applicable
- Trigger resource or corpse effects if applicable

How did you prototype this idea?

We use the original Jungle board and the referee randomly puts 5 resources on the board.

How many times did you playtest this idea?

We playtest 3 times of this version, with the last time removing the reward and corpse mechanic to control the playtime (we keep the hunger mechanic).

What were your feedback and observations?

All playtesters say the idea is really cool. Resource-based goals align better with the survival theme. Positive (buff) and negative (hunger) feedback create tension. The board remains close to Jungle Chess which is easy to learn. And players always have clear objectives.

HOWEVER, the game time is longer than we expected. It creates much more thinking time when we have these hunger, corpse mechanics. Players also need to remember all the buffs and temporary variations of pieces. So we remove the reward system and corpse mechanic and playtest again. I think this version runs pretty well since the playtime is shorter, while we keep the most exciting component (resource and hunger mechanics).

Overall, how successful was your prototype? Was it engaging? Did it adhere to your original vision? Is it worth pursuing and iterating on further?

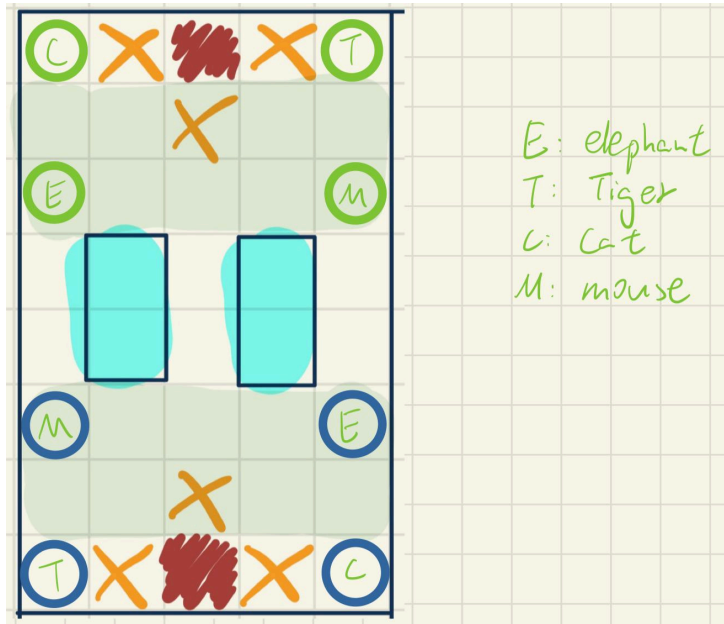
I think this prototype is very successful in making the game engaging, since capturing resources requires using more animals compared to the original version. It follows the concept of competing in forest in our original vision well. I believe it is worth pursuing and iterating on further. We plan to test the core loop with only resources + capture, and remove corpse and terrain to simplify. We will continue to try to optimize pacing to fit 10–15 minutes.

Prototype 3

What was the idea? The mechanics and the core loop.

The idea is to reduce the number of animals and minimize the size of the board.

The mechanics and the core loop keep the same. We made this change because we realize many animals were actually not being used in the original version, and this creates much more extra steps to rearrange the distribution of animals thus increasing the play time.



Board: 5x8 grid

Each player has 4 animal pieces now. Only elephant, tiger, cat, and mouse

Rules are the same as the original version.

How did you prototype this idea?

We draw the board in GoodNotes and move the pieces by circle and drag it.

How many times did you playtest this idea?

We've playtested this version twice. We can keep it under 10 minutes very well.

What were your feedback and observations?

This version simplifies the game too much. Players have less stuff to think while playing which reduces the playtime, but the downside is that it's less engaging because the strategy becomes fewer.

Overall, how successful was your prototype? Was it engaging? Did it adhere to your original vision? Is it worth pursuing and iterating on further?

This prototype is not successful. It's less engaging than the previous 2 prototypes because there's less room for maneuver, and it's easy to directly reach the destination because there's fewer animals to protect the home. It does adhere to the original vision, but it's too simplified. We will pursue other ideas further.

Prototype 4

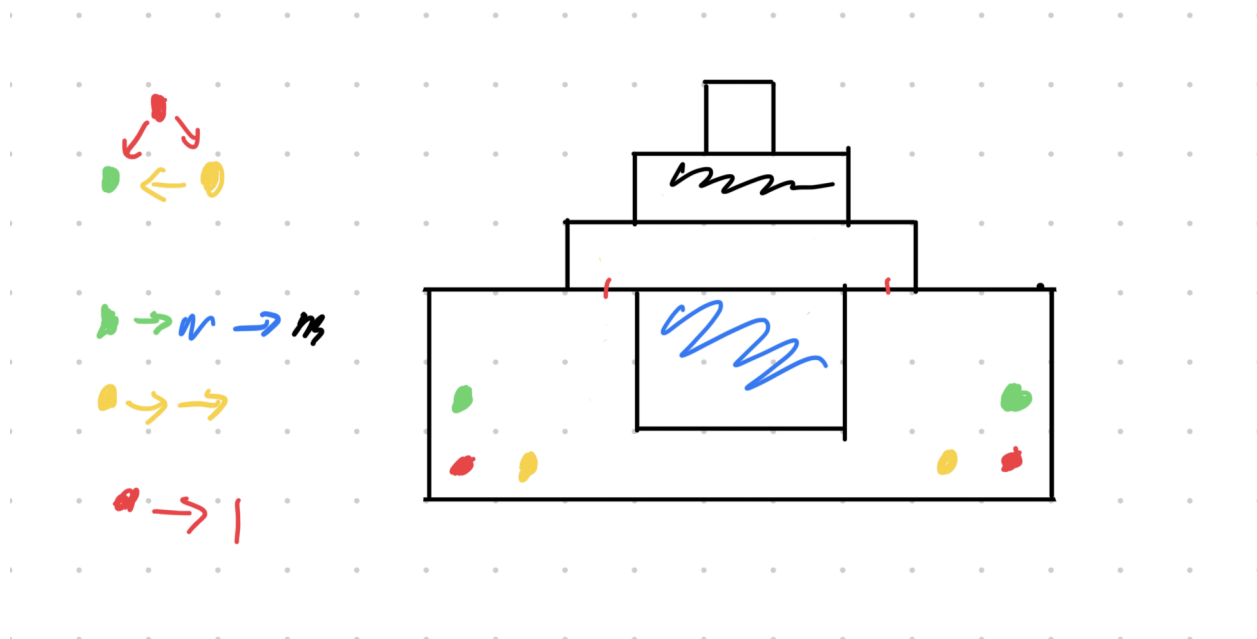
What was the idea? The mechanics and the core loop.

Instead of asking players to compete by trying to reach the opponent's den, I changed the goal of the game to having players compete to be the first to reach the top. The two players take turns moving their animals, attempting either to be the first to reach the top or to eliminate all of the opponent's animals. The number of animal types has been reduced from the original version, while their ranking system is largely preserved in a simplified form. The game board has also been modified to better fit the updated concept.

Overall, the core loop is similar to that of a chess game: a player takes actions based on the current board state, then the opponent takes their turn and updates the state. As described, the goal for both players is to be the first to reach the top.

How did you prototype this idea?

Here is the current map for this idea, which is still grid-based. Each player controls three different animals, with their starting positions shown on the map. Although not explicitly marked, the top tile represents the goal that players are trying to reach.



The ranking system is shown on the left: the red animal can eliminate both yellow and green, while the yellow animal can eliminate the green. Animals of the same rank can eliminate each other.

The 2×3 grid in the center represents water, and only the green animal can enter it. When the green animal is in the water, it can eliminate any opposing animal upon exiting a water cell. The yellow animal can move up to two cells per turn in any direction. For example, it can move two cells upward, or one cell upward and then one cell to the right.

At the top of the map, there is a locked tower. A red animal must first "break the lock" before any animal (regardless of ownership) can enter the tower.

How many times did you playtest this idea?

We have playedtest this idea once, which takes about 5 minutes.

What were your feedback and observations?

There are some problems within the map setup, such as the yellow chess seems to be moving too fast, and the green chess seems to be not strong enough. But in general, players seem to more or less enjoy the game.

Overall, how successful was your prototype? Was it engaging? Did it adhere to your original vision? Is it worth pursuing and iterating on further?

Overall, the prototype is at least interesting enough as it is based on the original game but creative enough and brings a lot of different tactical collisions. Players are engaging within this prototype, while we believe that it still adheres to the original vision. Thus, at this stage, I believe that it is worth pursuing and iterating on further.